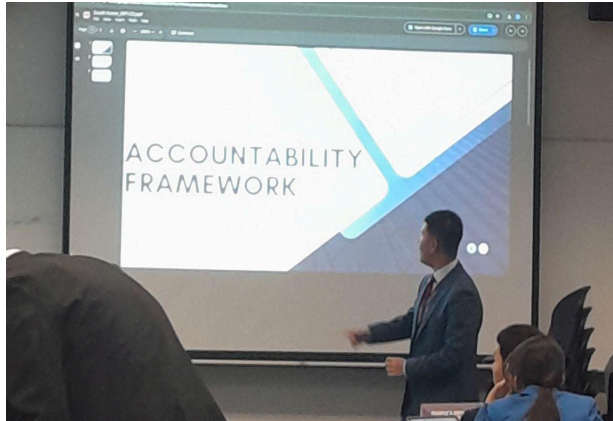


Opinion Editorial:**Name of Delegate:** Jadon Goh and Yip Juen Yu Caleb**Agency:** Bangkok Post**Title:** Tracking illegal trafficking of small arms and light weapons in SEA

Delegate of the Republic of Korea explaining his suggested Framework.

The illegal trafficking of weapons across borders has long been a concern due to factors such as the existence of the Golden Triangle. The illegal trafficking of arms and weapons results in the death of 700 people per day, showing the severity of this issue. Finally drawing attention from the ASEAN Ministerial Meeting of Transnational Crime, on the 22 June of 2026, the conference opened its first session for discussion.

For context, The Golden Triangle includes the following countries: China, Myanmar, Thailand, Laos and Vietnam ¹. This mountainous region is a hotspot for illegal activities and is the second largest drug-producing region after Latin America, ² a testament to the importance of preventing further escalation of crime within the region.

With such a pressing concern at hand, it was great to see such unanimous agreement amongst delegates. Delegates were quick to reach a consensus on the factors of weapons trafficking; stockpiling and corruption.

1. Vibhu Mishra. "Over 700 a day dying from small arms fire; main 'weapons of choice' for criminals and terrorists." UN News, December 15, 2023. <https://news.un.org/en/story/2023/12/1144867>

2. Payne, L. "Golden Triangle." Encyclopedia Britannica, June 12, 2025. <https://www.britannica.com/place/Golden-Triangle-region-Southeast-Asia>.

3. THE STRAITS TIMES. "Thai forces kill 9 'drug smugglers' in Golden Triangle." THE STRAITS TIMES, May 14, 2017. <https://www.straitstimes.com/asia/se-asia/thai-forces-kill-9-drug-smugglers-in-golden-triangle>

Despite this realisation however, the conference has proceeded to progress at an underwhelming pace. The definition of small arms and light weapons (SALW) has only been briefly touched on. It is crucial that the definitions are fully clarified as some countries do not have a fixed definition on SALW and failure to specify definitions could lead to committees having great difficulty implementing measures due to the great vagueness of what constitutes as SALW.

As for proposing solutions regarding how to combat the issues that arise from stockpiling and corruption, delegates of AMMTC have proposed implementing tracing systems by marking firearms to identify the origins and movements of weapons across borders. This will allow diversion of legal stockpiles and allow authorities to crack down on illegal trade routes.

One notable proposal is from the delegate of The Republic of Korea. The idea would be to integrate Radio-Frequency Identification (RFID) Trackers into newly produced weapons. These trackers would also be unique to countries in ASEAN. However, the conference is yet to decide on a specific way to mark and track arms as there have been various methods proposed.

Presently, the specifics are still being decided. However further collaboration on this idea appears promising. Currently, on 22 June 2026, the initiative, dubbed the “Accountability Framework” , is being funded by the members of ASEAN, the Gulf Cooperation Council and the Republic of Korea.

Of course, with some specifics still undecided, there were some reasonable concerns raised. How does this stop weapons already in illegal circulation? The Republic of Korea responded, “As for weapons already in circulation, since this system would reveal where weapons are trafficked to/thus leading us to the hotspots of the weapons.”

Thailand is also involved in the “Accountability Framework”. The initiative itself is a non-aggressive and collaborative effort, which aligns with Thailand’s and ASEAN’s principals of neutrality and non violence. This safe, and recommended, move by Thailand has now shown its collaborative spirit and willingness to resolve the issue.

Notwithstanding the inconsistencies, the conference is still at its infantile stage and is showing promising results. Moving forward, delegates should quickly settle on a unanimous definition of SALWs as well as settle on a means of tracking weapons in order to contribute to a fruitful discussion pertaining to this pertinent issue.

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